

GCE Religious Studies

OCR Advanced Subsidiary GCE in Religious Studies H172

OCR Advanced GCE in Religious Studies H572

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specification

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Vertical black lines indicate a significant change to the previous printed version. Changes can be found on pages 13, 44 and 65.

This booklet contains OCR's Advanced Subsidiary GCE and Advanced GCE specifications in Religious Studies for teaching from September 2008.

This specification builds on the knowledge, understanding and skills that candidates may have developed through the study of GCSE Religious Studies. It does not, however, assume or require any previous study of the subject. It is designed to support a course of study which is suitable for candidates from any religious background (or none).

At AS candidates select **two** complementary areas of study from the wide range permitted in the specification. At A2 it is recommended that candidates continue to follow the same subject areas selected at AS. Candidates are free however to select different units at A2 than those studied at AS. In such cases it should be noted that candidates should familiarise themselves with the contents of the corresponding AS, as they may be disadvantaged by not studying the areas covered at AS. The specification, however, is designed to be flexible and does permit combinations of up to four different subject areas for the Advanced GCE qualification. As required by the Subject Criteria, the Advanced GCE specification includes synoptic assessment, in which candidates are asked to show their understanding of the connections between their chosen areas of study and other specified aspects of human experience. This is incorporated fully into the content of all A2 units.

The specification incorporates:

- continuity of content in the areas of the Philosophy of Religion, Religious Ethics, World Religions and Textual papers;
- flexibility in allowing combinations of up to four areas of study in the subject;
- maintenance of established methods of assessment: the need for candidates to answer questions at the full Advanced level with essays which they must plan and structure for themselves;
- the practice of positive awarding, by which examiners are not restricted by a prescriptive marking scheme but are able to reward candidates for any valid response to a reasonable interpretation of the question according to its quality as measured against standard band descriptions.

The specification is linked closely with the OCR GCSE Religious Studies specifications, in both content and in progression of demand.

In AS units, candidates are asked two-part structured questions which relate directly to single areas within the associated module. The questions help candidates to structure their answers to meet the Assessment Objectives.

In A2 units, candidates are expected to display knowledge, understanding and evaluative skills in respect to the specified topics. They are asked essay-style questions in which they may be expected to use material from more than one area within the unit, to draw comparisons and to assess the relative significance of different aspects of the unit. The questions direct candidates towards the Assessment Objectives, but candidates are expected to select their own material and structure it themselves into a coherent answer.

The AS GCE and Advanced GCE specifications require candidates to:

Study one or more of the following areas within Religious Studies:

- philosophy of religion;
- religious ethics;
- textual studies;
- theological studies;
- history of religious tradition(s).

Candidates should acquire knowledge and understanding of:

- the key concepts within the chosen area(s) of study (eg religious beliefs, teachings, doctrines, principles, ideas and theories) and how these are expressed in texts, writings and/or practices;
- the contribution of significant people, traditions or movements to the area(s) studied;
- religious language and terminology;
- major issues and questions arising from the chosen area(s) of study;
- the relationship between the chosen area(s) of study and other specified aspects of human experience.

Candidates should develop the following skills:

- recall, select and deploy specified knowledge;
- identify, investigate and analyse questions and issues arising from the course of study;
- use appropriate language and terminology in context;
- interpret and evaluate religious concepts, issues and ideas, the relevance of arguments and the views of scholars;
- communicate, using reasoned arguments substantiated by evidence;
- develop the skill of making connections between the area(s) of study chosen and other specified aspects of human experience.

In addition, the Advanced GCE specification requires candidates to:

1.1 The Two-Unit AS

The Advanced Subsidiary GCE is both a 'stand-alone' qualification and also the first half of the corresponding Advanced GCE. The AS GCE is assessed at a standard appropriate for candidates who have completed the first year of study (both in terms of teaching time and content) of the corresponding two-year Advanced GCE course, ie between GCSE and Advanced GCE.

From September 2008 the AS GCE is made up of **two** mandatory units chosen from **nine** options, which are externally assessed and form 50% of the corresponding four-unit Advanced GCE.

1.2 The Four-Unit Advanced GCE

From September 2008 the Advanced GCE is made up of **two** mandatory units at AS and **two** further units at A2, again chosen from nine options. These A2 units are also externally assessed.

1.3 Qualification Titles and Levels

These qualifications are shown on a certificate as:

- OCR Advanced Subsidiary GCE in Religious Studies.
- OCR Advanced GCE in Religious Studies.

Both qualifications are Level 3 in the National Qualification Framework (NQF).

1.4 Aims

The aims of these specifications are to encourage candidates to:

- develop their interest in and enthusiasm for a rigorous study of religion and relate it to the wider world;
- treat the subject as an academic discipline by developing knowledge, understanding and skills appropriate to the specialist study of religion;
- adopt an enquiring, critical and reflective approach to the study of religion;

1.5 Prior Learning/Attainment

No prior knowledge of the subject is required. The specifications build on, but do not depend on, the knowledge, understanding and skills specified for GCSE Religious Studies. It is recommended that candidates have attained communication and literacy skills at a level equivalent to GCSE Grade C in English.

2.1 AS Units

Unit G571: *AS Philosophy of Religion*

- Ancient Greek influences on philosophy of religion;
- Judaeo-Christian influences on philosophy of religion;
- Traditional arguments for the existence of God;
- Challenges to religious belief.

Unit G572: *AS Religious Ethics*

- Ethical theories;
- Applied ethics topics.

Unit G573: *AS Jewish Scriptures*

- Time line of scriptures;
- Form criticism;
- Topics.

Unit G574: *AS New Testament*

- First century Gospel setting;
- Themes and texts of Mark's passion narrative;
- The resurrection in the Synoptic Gospels.

G575: *AS Developments in Christian Theology*

- Foundations of Christian theology;
- Liberation theology.

Unit G576: *AS Buddhism*

- Origins of Buddhism;

- Origins of Hinduism;
- Core concepts;
- Key teachings, attitudes and practices.

Unit G578: AS *Islam*

- Background and origins of Islam;
- Beliefs;
- Practices.

G579: AS *Judaism*

- Sacred writings;
 - Beliefs;
 - Practices.
-

2.2 A2 Units

Unit G581: A2 *Philosophy of Religion*

- Religious language;
- Experience and religion;
- Nature of God;
- Life and death;
- Miracle.

Unit G582: A2 *Religious Ethics*

- Meta-ethics;
- Free will and determinism;
- Conscience;

- Reward and punishment;
 - Amos and Hosea;
 - Messianic hope and the ethical kingdom;
 - Ruth;
 - Wisdom literature and religious experience.
-

- Theology of religions;
- Feminist theology.

Unit G586: A2 *Buddhism*

- Key concepts;
- The importance of scriptures;
- Religious practice;
- Later Buddhist developments;
- Ethics.

Unit G587: A2 *Hinduism*

- Key concepts;
- The importance of scriptures;
- Religious practice;
- Later Hindu developments;
- Ethics.

Unit G588: A2 *Islam*

- Beliefs;
- Muslim life;
- Development of Islam.

Unit G589: A2 *Judaism*

- Beliefs;
- Developments in Judaism.

3.1 G571: AS *Philosophy of Religion*

Ancient Greek influences on philosophy of religion

Candidates are expected to have a basic knowledge of the thinking of Plato and Aristotle; they will not be expected to have first-hand knowledge of the texts. They should be able to highlight the strengths and weaknesses in the thinking of Plato and Aristotle in the areas specified below.

Plato: the Analogy of the Cave

Candidates should be able to demonstrate